dian fighter for freedom to the 1857 rebellion in Meerut. "The *sipahi* who revolted in Meerut and Kanpur," he says, "was not from Meerut and Kanpur. The Indian soldier to this day, the Indian jawan is a *kisan* in uniform. He has to reflect the mood of the villages."

In this sense, *The Last Heroes* is as much about present-day India as it is about the struggle for Independence. Referring to the farmers' protests in Delhi over the last year, he says, "there were dozens and dozens of ex-servicemen and about 200 medals looking out at me when I was speaking onstage." In the People's Archive of Rural India (PARI), the award-winning multimedia platform Sainath founded in 2014, a reporter published a story about five of these soldiers, 63 medals between them. "These," Sainath says sardonically, "were the anti-nationals and Khalistanis."

Ordinary people, Sainath emphasises throughout his book, are not motivated by ambition or acclaim but by freedom. For them, it is an existential struggle—a desire to protect their land, their livelihoods and their way of life. Despite the solace, the book takes in the extraordinary spirit of ordinary freedom fighters, despite the book's optimism, it cannot escape a plaintive underlying note of elegy.

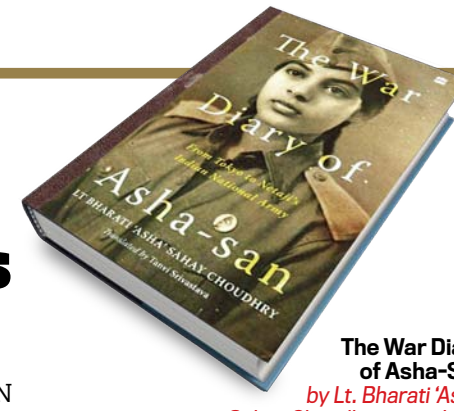
"We fought for two things," reads the book's epigraph, a quote from Captain Bhau, the subject of the book's sixth chapter, "for freedom and Independence. We attained Independence." Sadly, it will be up to future generations to attain freedom. Ultimately, this is the message of Sainath's book and his journalism. That the struggle continues. It remains up to ordinary people to resist the excesses of power. And it will be up to a dwindling number of independent-minded journalists to record the people's resistance. ■

Shougat Dasgupta

BOOKS

The Triumphs of Youth

WE EXPECTEDLY FIND IN THE DIARIES OF A TEENAGE FREEDOM FIGHTER AN EQUAL DOSE OF NAIVETE AND STRENGTH



The War Diary of Asha-San
by Lt. Bharati 'Asha' Sahay Choudhry; translated by Tanvi Srivastava
HARPER COLLINS
Rs 599; 225 pages

Bharati Asha Sahay was born in Kobe in 1928, to a Bengali mother and Bihari father. The parents, being fervent nationalists, named their first-born after Bharat and Asha for the hope for independence. Bharati's father, Anand Mohan Sahay, worked with different leaders of the independence movement in India and with Rashbehari Bose in Japan. When Subhash Chandra Bose (no relation) finally escaped from the British, he made his way from Hitler's Germany to Tojo's Japan in 1943. Rashbehari, who had founded the Indian National Army, handed over command to Subhash. Bharati, called Asha-san by her Japanese friends, is 15 years old, and to all purposes a Japanese schoolgirl of Indian descent, when she first meets Netaji Subhash. In her diary—originally written in Japanese—she states: 'The soldiers of the INA will fight alongside the Japanese in Burma. Together means no hierarchy, no inferiority.' A few pages later, her hero-worship of Subhash is palpable: 'Neither is it possible to shy away our eyes because of his shimmering charm: he is a divine spectre who brings clarity and consciousness on sight.'

Anand Sahay becomes one of Bose's closest political advisors, joining the cabinet of the Provisional Government of Azad Hind. In the first quarter of 1945, his daughter Asha, now 17, receives her newly stitched uniform of the Rani of Jhansi Regiment (RJR). As the diary recounts, she accompanies her father and makes her way to join the women's regiment of the INA. The 'war diary' properly



DEAR DIARY
Lt. Bharati 'Asha' Sahay Choudhry

begins at this point, when father and daughter stop in Formosa and young Asha participates in a sending-off ceremony for a group of young kamikaze pilots who are about to take off. The narrative then takes us through Asha's training in Thailand, the rising tide of bad news that swirls around the RJR trainees as they go through their paces, the surrender of the Japanese after the atom bombs, the news of Subhash's death in the air-crash in Formosa, the capture of the INA soldiers and women cadets by the Anglo-American forces who take Bangkok, and then the events leading up to the release of the INA's leadership, including Asha's father and uncle, ending with Independence in 1947.

At times the diary is naive, as is to be expected from a teenager's jottings, and at times it is repetitive. With a fuller knowledge of that time, we know that the 'no hierarchy, no inferiority' between the Japanese and the INA was a complete lie; we know that for all his charisma, Subhash was a highly egotistical, myopic and compromised leader who was cynically manipulated by the Fascist Axis leaders. And yet, when you read the words of one of the songs sung by the INA at the time you realise this book is a precious snapshot of the idealism in which a young woman of that time was steeped: 'On my mother's head rests a crown/ the gardens of India are green/ with the flowers of Nehru, Gandhi, Vallabhbhai, Azad and Ansari in our laps, Subhash will be victorious... On my mother's head rests a crown/ may there be love between Hindus and Muslims/ may our brothers be affable...' ■

Ruchir Joshi